

KORANTINE RITES

Designing a quasi-ancient society for Mythras and other RPGs

by Jonathan Drake

Part II: HARD CASH



COINAGE

The Gold Piece (GP) has often served as the fantasy gaming world's currency of choice. But throughout history the high price of gold has made it much more useful for transporting a lot of value around in a small amount of metal and handling high-ticket transactions than for doing day-to-day business. The precious metal of choice in Mythras, as in the real ancient world, is the Silver Piece (SP).

Before the invention of coined money silver already served a unit of exchange just by just weighing out the metal. Coined money formalises things by providing reassurance in the form of a stamp applied to a piece of metal that it meets a specified weight standard and that you can rely on the purity of the metal in the coin. Or at least that you can rely on the willingness of other people to recognise and accept the value the coin is supposed to have when you go shopping.

Getting your head around real-world ancient currency can be pretty difficult. Competing and confusing money systems abound. Decimalisation was centuries in the future, so a bewildering variety of fractions are in use. And while there were standards, there were also debasements of currencies to keep up with runaway inflation or a squeeze on the availability of precious metals.

The Phoenicians, well known as international traders, devised a standard based on the a silver *Shekel*, about 7.2g of silver (rather less than the Shekel you would encounter in the Bronze Age). With the conquest of Phoenicia by Alexander the Great and of Carthage by Rome the Phoenician standard falls into obscurity. In the Greek world there were several competing standards, but the Athenian silver drachm weighing 4.3g became the most widely recognised, not least because the Athenians had seemingly unlimited supply of silver and, for a while, an empire they could impose their money on. The Athenian ('Attic') standard was later adopted by Alexander the Great and his

successors who had so much looted Persian silver and gold to turn into coins that they dominated the money-minting business across the East for generations. And in the Roman world, after a lot of experimenting and a financial meltdown caused by Hannibal, the silver *Denarius* weighing 4.5g was created during the Punic Wars (late 3rd BCE) and remained in use for some 450 years, albeit with declining weight and purity over time.

As the basic building block of our currency system we are going to begin with:

1 Silver Piece (SP)



It's a little coin about 2cm across, no more than 5 grams in weight of almost pure silver (more than 95%). You can feel it nicely in your hand, but it's small enough to easily conceal, tuck in your mouth (in a world without pockets), palm it or drop without realising. On it are struck the symbols and legends of whoever you are to believe will guarantee its value. Perhaps the name and emblem of a city on one side, the image of a goddess or king on the other. It may bear tiny letters proclaiming who made it, and in whose name. Sometimes an astonishing, miniature work of art.

Whether by accident or design, the value of 1 SP can be a really useful benchmark. 1 Silver Piece is what you might get as wages for a day's labour as a skilled worker or perhaps a soldier. It's also equivalent in value to one *peck* of grain, a key measure of agricultural produce, of which more later.

If you are supporting a family on 1SP per day there will be nothing much left even if you all live rather frugally. But if you are young, free

and single, like a lot of soldiers, you will be able to get a few extra jars of wine with your dinner, and if you don't drink your spare cash away you could end up with some small change at the end of the day. Fractions of 1 SP can be really, really small if also made out of silver. The Romans used the *Sestertius* as a standard of account, which is a quarter of a denarius and therefore a silver coin weighing 1.125g. Little coins weighing even less than a gram were also common, like the tiny Athenian *Obol* which was 1/6 of a drachm in value. So it's a bit more user-friendly, and easier on the silver reserves, if instead you make bigger coins out of cheaper metal. Like bronze (copper and tin) or, more rarely, just copper. Or even brass (copper and zinc). Eventually the Romans gave up striking little silver sestertii and instead made big shiny brass ones.

1 Copper Piece (BP)



As we have seen, in the ancient world your loose change is more likely to be bronze than copper. Bronze is harder, resists corrosion much better, and is more widely recognised as a useful metal that you can make attractive and desirable objects from if you have enough of it. So let's call it a Bronze Piece (BP).

For example, the Republican Roman *As* is about 3cm across, weighing in at a hefty 30g or more. The Roman *Denarius* gets its name because it means 'tenner', and it was originally worth 10 Bronze *Asses*.

The metal content of a Bronze Piece is not worth the face value of the coin. Bronze is in fact typically worth only 1% of equivalent weight in silver. And there were people, like the

Romans at early stages of their development, who issued great big lumps of bronze that were supposed to have a value related to their metal content. But in all practical senses a bronze coin's worth is really just what the moneyer says it is, and peoples' willingness to put their faith in something as a token of value. This is quite a revolutionary step.

At 1/10 of a Silver Piece, 1 Bronze Piece will buy you a cheap meal, or a loaf of bread. You can have fractions and multiples of a BP, but the weight ratios between different Bronze coin denominations needs to stay internally consistent. You can go down to a coin worth 0.2BP and still have a more substantial coin than your standard silver piece, but higher denominations do get progressively bigger and heavier, so a 2BP coin is practical but a 4 BP or 5 BP coin quite a lump of metal.

Higher Denominations

Carrying a lot of bronze and even silver pieces can be irksome, but that's where higher denomination coins come in. Large Silver Pieces might come in at 2x, 4x or, more rarely, 10x the size and value of the standard unit. One of the most popular coins of the ancient world is a 4-drachm coin, the *tetradrachm*. It is a lovely thing to hold. Still only 25mm across but a thick coin weighing in at a little over 17g. It's also big enough to really give the coin engraver space to show off their artistry.

This doesn't of course change how much sheer weight in silver you have to haul away when you strike it rich on your adventures. All very well if you defeat a group of bandits and plunder their lair to find it contains hundreds of SPs in coin. But a bit of a challenge if the 'coin' is all in bronze denominations because it's been looted from ordinary folk who don't carry much precious metal around with them.

For big numbers, gold works much better...

1 Gold Piece (GP)



Gold is typically worth 10 or 12 times the equivalent weight of silver. But a gold coin the same size and shape as a Silver Piece weighs twice as much, and is usually higher purity. So a single gold coin, 2cm across and weighting in at about 10g, can be pegged at 25SP. A frugal family could live off the purchasing power of that one coin for the best part of a month. Many states don't issue gold coins at all, there's simply not enough demand for them, nobody carries enough change for when confronted with a Gold Piece in payment, and if you are going to mint a lot of gold coins you also need access to plenty of gold to do it.

Sometimes you need to account for even bigger sums of money. Then it really comes down to old-fashioned weight in bullion. The standard large unit is a *Talent*. How much a talent weighs depends yet again on precisely where and when you are in history, but a little under 30kg is a good rule of thumb (many variants existed, but let's keep it simple). A Talent of silver represents 6,000 Silver Pieces, more than enough to live like a wealthy aristocrat for a year. It can be broken down into 60 *Mina* worth 1,000 SP each.

And if you really want to feel rich, find yourself a talent of gold. A talent of gold weighs the same as a silver talent but is almost half the size and worth 12 times as much, so a whopping 72,000 SP. Enough to buy you not just one, but two triremes, and still have some change.

Money Changers

Every city likes to mint its own coins, and it is quite common that a city only permits its own

coins to be used within its territory. A money changer will be more than happy to convert to local currency for a small commission (5%). Once there are Empires in place then the coins issued under its rule have wider currency. Although even in the Roman Empire, coins struck in the East routinely used Greek standard weights and denominations while coins struck in the West used Roman ones.

Debasing Currency and other Fraud...

If a city or kingdom gets into financial difficulties, such as running out of bullion to meet their target for newly minted coins, they may start to reduce the size of the coins. This could be a creeping process over many years, or it could be an executive decision to change the standard as a one-off reform. And then you can require visitors to your lands (or even your own people) to trade their old currency for your shiny new coins at 1:1 as a kind of tax. Tampering with the standards in this way only works if you are a big city or an empire where everyone has to play along.

Or you might debase your currency, that is, the moneyers reduce the normal purity of the coins by adding cheaper metals. When this happens the state's own credit rating is paramount. The coinage is now only worth what it says it is if the issuing authorities can be relied upon to make good upon its face value.

Finally, you may encounter market officials in key trading hubs who a trader can go to with any suspect coins for a decision on whether they are what they say they are, or are legal tender. Foreign imitations of local coins may be acceptable if they meet purity standards. Officially produced coins that are debased or underweight will also get approved - in fact most likely it is compulsory to accept them. But counterfeiting coins - for example by coating a base metal core in silver as an act of fraud - brings the death penalty.

Unit	Description	Value in SP
1 Silver Talent	30KG of silver	6,000 SP
1 Mina of Silver	0.5KG of silver	100 SP
1 Gold Piece	10g gold coin	25 SP
1 Large Silver Piece	20g silver coin	4 SP
1 Silver Piece	5g silver coin	1 SP
1 Small Silver Piece	1.25g silver coin	0.25 SP
1 Brass Piece	30g brass coin	0.25 SP
1 Bronze Piece	30g bronze Coin	0.1 SP

So if your adventurers stumble upon a big hoard of silver pieces, it may be those silver pieces are not pure – or legal tender. And what they think is a massive pile of cash is worth a fraction of what they believe. Conversely, they may come across some hoard of ancient coins that are in fact almost pure bullion, and the reverse may apply. In Mythras, a useful Folk Magic spell would be one that tests the purity of a quantity of coins, or weighs a product or substance without access to a scale.

To conclude, our fantasy ancient money system can take advantage of some more modern measures and some easier maths but still be close enough to ancient realities to make sense. We'll assume the base weight of a standard silver coin is 5g, and a gold coin of the same size is 10g. You can add colour and detail, if you want to, by adding in coins which are fractions or multiples of the core GP, SP and BP types.

THE BREAD LINE

While your Adventurers may be looking for a price for a shiny new sword or the cost of a healer, the wider economy is more concerned with basic costs of living. And all things begin with having enough to eat.

A happy citizen is one who knows that they can afford their daily bread. A typical human needs to consume 1,800-3,000 Kcal depending on age, gender and how physically demanding

their lives and work can be. In our quasi-ancient world these calories usually arrive in the form of wheat bread, but in areas where wheat doesn't grow well (due to poor rainfall) barley may be used instead. A loaf of bread costing 1BP weighs 1lb, or 0.45Kg, and it will provide about 1,100 Kcal. So 2BP spent on bread will just about sustain a typical adult for a day.

As it happens the price of bread is twice that cost of the grain required to make it. The difference between the two is accounted for by storage, transport, milling, and baking, plus any loss or spoilage. This is a reasonable starting point and is borne out by the relative costs of grain and bread in the ancient sources. While country folk may be able to do all of this for themselves, the more people cram together into crowded cities, living in places with nowhere to prepare and cook food for themselves, the more they have to rely on people like the baker. If the poorest are priced out even of bread it is up to the city authorities, or perhaps a rich benefactor, to provide some kind of corn dole.

But there's more to life than bread...

Once you take into account that, before the modern era, food typically accounts for some half of all expenditure, then we can double up the minimum cost of food to find typical minimum outgoings, which gives us a requirement of 4BP per day, 144SP per year, as more or less the minimum required to live without some kind of dependency on someone else. But it is nowhere near enough if you have mouths to feed besides your own. Historians sometimes use an assumption that the head of the household accounts for 40% of expenditure, which gives us a multiple of x2.5 to reach the amount required to sustain a family at the same level. Hence an income of 360SP, or 1SP per day, is what is required for an average family of two adults and 2-3 children or other dependants without falling into absolute poverty or dependency.

ADVENTURER LIFESTYLES

This table takes a broad view of the money needed for an individual Adventurer to enjoy a certain lifestyle. This might be useful in calculating cost of downtime, but also there will be occasions where an Adventurer might spend a lot of money for a short period of time to give the impression she is richer than she is.

A suggestion is also made here regarding starting money if you are using the price guides in this article, given that the standard 4D6x75SP might prove inappropriate for a pauper on the bread line.

INHERITANCE

An Adventurer may be in line to inherit a plot of land. Primogeniture, in which the eldest son inherits his father's lands and title by default, is a medieval invention. In a quasi-ancient economy property is normally divided up between the surviving sons and possibly daughters – or anyone else that the deceased has nominated in his will. This can of course lead to small farms being partitioned into uneconomically small units. And as Social Class is often derived from the amount of land held or equivalent, division of an estate may downgrade the Social Class of the next generation. Keeping an estate together may result in their being 'spare' heirs forced to go

and find their own fortune because a sibling has the family farm. This is one reason why people might go adventuring, sign up as a mercenary or join a colonisation expedition. It also leads to a great deal of intrigue, plot and politics over the inheritance of large estates, and even of very small ones – because inheritance can be lifechanging at any level. Inheritance has a lot of potential in conjunction with Family and Connections table (CRB p.25) to really root an adventurer in their background.

We can use the Adventurer Lifestyles table to get an idea of what an inheritance could be worth. Assuming an Adventurer's parents are of the same Social Class as decided for the Adventurer, let's assume the parental estate is enough to furnish that lifestyle for a family, with something to spare. A reasonable value for that estate is something like 5 times its output. So a poor farmer or cobbler might inherit a share of an estate worth 144SP (annual upkeep) x 2.5 (family modifier) x 5 (valuation multiplier) = 1,800SP.

However when we reach the leisured classes, the Rich Estate Owner, Aristocrat or Magnate, we need to consider that they living off only a portion of the total output of their property in rents or profits, for which 5% or 6% is a reasonable figure to use. So with that in mind we need to add another multiplier. An aristocrat's estate could be 5,000SP (annual upkeep) x 1.25 (family modifier) x 20 (to find

ADVENTURER LIFESTYLES TABLE

Lifestyle	Daily Upkeep	Monthly Upkeep	Annual Upkeep	Family and household Multiplier	Suggested Starting Money
<i>Pauper</i>	2BP	6SP	72SP	x2.5	D6 SP (average 35BP)
<i>Poor Townsman or Subsistence Farmer</i>	4BP	12SP	144SP	x2.5	2D6x 10SP (average 70SP)
<i>Yeoman Farmer or Artisan</i>	6BP	16SP	216SP	x2.5	2D6x 25SP (average 175SP)
<i>Affluent Merchant, Business Owner or Landowner</i>	14BP	40SP	500SP	x2	4D6x 75SP (average 1,050SP)
<i>Rich Estate Owner</i>	28BP	80SP	1,000SP	x1.5	6D6x 100SP (average 2,100SP)
<i>Aristocrat or Land Magnate</i>	14SP	400SP	5,000SP	x1.25	2D6x 1,000SP (average 7,000SP)

the total productive output based on 5% rate of return) x 5 (valuation multiplier), for a total of 625,000SP. Which is a great deal of money. Of course it's appropriate to introduce some randomisation. Value is in some regards always subjective, and maybe a property is close to the city or an important road making it especially desirable, or perhaps its buildings are run down or it is so close to hostile territory it suffers frequent depredations from raiders, making it rather less so. A simple way to do reflect this would be to use 1d6+2 as the valuation multiplier.

WAGES

If adventures have not yet delivered a haul of loot to live off until the next time, you may need to find other ways to earn some ready money until the next opportunity presents itself. Outside of military service there are very few long term, salaried jobs available. Almost everyone is self-employed, making their living by cultivating their own little plot of land, or making goods to sell. Which means you need some land, or a workshop, raw materials and all the tools of the trade. If you don't have those things nor the cash to acquire them your options are very limited. Making some extra money by hiring on as casual labour on construction projects in the city, or as seasonal labour out in the fields opportunities for topping up income, but enough to support a family.

The Adventurer Wages Table provides some pay rates based on known ancient examples.

Unfortunately while many jobs are available by the day there are not 360 working days in the year. Even before weekends are invented, you have to assume there are perhaps 100 days of the year on which no work or business takes place because of festivals, holy days and the like. Jobs marked with an * are those where the employer is providing some basic maintenance – food and housing or expenses – in addition to the wage, so this is 'take home'.

Military rates of pay tend to be high. The income shown here is also expected to be boosted with cash bonuses, booty, and even a grant of land at the end of service. This is because professional soldiers can cause a lot of trouble if they get fed up with their pay and ordinary citizens need to see an upside to taking time out to serve in the militia.

While self-sufficiency is the dream, most people need additional sources of income to support a family. This could mean balancing the demands of cultivating a smallholding of one's own while also working for others for pay. It can also mean taking handouts from wealthier patrons in return for loyalty or votes; state payments for performing civic duties such as jury duty or militia service; or earnings generated by other members of the household – including children sent out to work. Perhaps several of these factors working together can make for a far more comfortable living with a bit of a safety net when things go wrong.

ADVENTURER WAGES TABLE			
*rates are in addition to basic maintenance			
Job	Daily	Monthly	Annual
<i>Low-Skilled Craftsman or Labourer</i>	6BP	-	-
<i>Skilled Craftsman (e.g. Cook, Stonemason, Blacksmith)</i>	13BP	28SP	
<i>Elite Artisan (e.g. Artist, Doctor)</i>	4SP	90SP	-
<i>Secretary, Scribe or Teacher</i>	15BP	40SP	-
<i>Messenger*</i>	7BP	-	-
<i>Priest, Soothsayer, Temple attendant*</i>	7BP	16SP	192SP
<i>Soldier (Professional)*</i>	1SP	20SP	250SP
<i>Soldier (Militia)*</i>	5BP	15SP	-
<i>Army Officer (Centurion)</i>	22SP	480SP	5760SP

THE PRICE OF GOODS

Some basic items can cost a considerable proportion of your earnings, and some are far less costly than you may have thought – or that most RPGs allow for. On the whole the prices given below provide a reasonable approximation for a ‘realistic’ price model using patchy ancient data. On the whole your Silver Piece is going to go a lot further than it does in Rules as Written, and perhaps adventurers everywhere should have a little more respect for the power and value of that shiny little coin...

Metals

An adventurer may need a quantity of metal to be shaped into something useful by a craftsman, or perhaps be wondering whether a haul of metalwork from the latest expedition might have value as scrap. Precious metals are very much pegged to their value as currency, but other metals by their abundance or general usefulness.

Metals	
Lead, 1kg	1BP
Iron, 1kg	4BP
Copper, 1kg	11BP
Bronze, 1kg	2SP
Silver, 1kg	200SP
Gold, 1kg	2,400SP

Food

While staples provide the most calories at the best price, they make for a monotonous diet. The poor can supplement the staples with things they can forage, and will venture a few BPs to make their basic food more appetising or nutritious. A quasi-ancient world relies not just on grain, but on wine – drunk diluted with water, but all the same quaffed in prodigious quantities every day, doing the same job as beer in other cultures. And of course olives: to eat, but especially to press for oil, which is not just a food in itself but also a source of cooking oil, lamp oil, body oil and axle grease. Olive trees

Staples	
Loaf of bread	1BP
Barley	1BP per kg
Wheat	1.5BP per kg
Rye	1BP per kg
Honey	1SP, 2BP per litre
Barley flour	2BP per kg
Wheat flour	2.5BP per kg
Salt	1BP per kg
Olive Oil	1BP per litre

are hardy, grow on marginal land and the harvest is in the autumn perhaps just before sowing the grain fields.

Meat animals are often butchered as part of a sacrifice, whether public or private, then distributed to all those entitled a share. If your quasi-ancient world emulates real world ancient religion at all, the space in front of those lovely pillared temples will often have all the sights and smells of an abattoir. Rearing animals for meat is an expensive business unless you have access to a lot of pasture, but even small farmer might keep a few goats, pigs and fowl that don't take up too much grazing land. Pigs give you the best bang for your buck (or BP) in terms of calories, and as they will eat pretty much anything are not so hard to keep.

Meat and Fish	
Pork	5BP per kg
Mutton	1SP per kg
Goat	4BP per kg
Beef	6BP per kg
Game bird, e.g. duck, partridge, pheasant	1.5SP per bird
Poultry, domesticated fowl e.g. duck or chicken	1SP per bird
Venison	5BP per kg
Crustaceans and Premium Saltwater Fish	8BP per kg
Other Saltwater Fish	5BP per kg
Freshwater Fish	3BP per kg
Preserved (salted) Fish	2BP per kg

In a quasi-ancient world fishing is an important source of protein, and even poorer folk can catch a fish or two with a simple line from the shore, while fishermen peg out fish traps and

nets or take to boats in search of the bays and inlets where fish gather. Lookout towers are set up to spot the approach of shoals, and those settlements lucky enough to have a migrating schools of big premium fish like tuna passing through their waters may declare it a publicly owned resource, same as a silver mine. Salt is usually abundant, so fish can be salted to last in storage or be transported abroad. Exotic fish, crustacea and some of the best shellfish find their way to the tables of the rich, and in the Imperial World there may even be commercial fish farms to feed demand.

Drinks	
<i>Wine, Fine</i>	2SP per litre
<i>Wine, Good</i>	1SP per litre
<i>Wine, Basic</i>	2BP-4BP per litre
<i>Ale, Premium</i>	2BP per litre

Tools

Iron means that even the simplest tools can now have metal fittings – back in the bronze age stone, bone, antler and other materials were still pressed into service as all metal remained in some respect precious.

Tools	
<i>Adze or Hoe</i>	1SP
<i>Axe, Hatchet</i>	2SP
<i>Axe, Tree Felling</i>	3SP
<i>Pick</i>	3SP
<i>Ploughshare and Board</i>	7SP
<i>Scythe</i>	1SP
<i>Shovel</i>	1.5SP
<i>Work Maul</i>	1SP
<i>Yoke for Oxen*</i>	10SP

Clothing

Here's the surprise. Woven cloth is *really* expensive. There's a huge amount of time, effort and investment in raising the sheep or growing the flax, gathering and processing, spinning, weaving and dyeing. So clothing is an expensive necessity, you have to really be quite wealthy to be regularly changing your clothes.

One reason perhaps that a simple, wrap around piece of cloth is so popular. Tailoring is not very advanced, and most garments are simple in construction requiring a particular technique of wrapping or pinning with a brooch to keep them secure. The poorest folk and slaves might have no more than a simple shift of unbleached wool to their name, or even something sewn together from scraps. It also explains why people in antiquity got so exercised about what we might consider petty thefts (such as having your cloak stolen at the baths).

Clothing and Leather Goods	
<i>Basic tunic or shift of unbleached wool</i>	2SP
<i>Simple Tunic</i>	4SP
<i>Tailored and Dyed Tunic</i>	7SP
<i>Tailored, Dyed and Decorated Tunic</i>	15SP
<i>Basic Cloak or Mantle</i>	1SP 2BP
<i>Fine Cloak</i>	30SP
<i>Fine imported cloak, dyed and decorated</i>	75SP
<i>Basic Shoes or Sandals</i>	8BP
<i>High Status Shoes</i>	1SP 5BP
<i>Military or Working Boots</i>	1SP 2BP

The most expensive clothes – for example a cloak made from rare and superfine textiles such as silk, imported from far away and adorned with silver and gold thread can cost *hundreds* of Silver Pieces. Garments on this level may be restricted, either under laws designed to prevent the rich showing off too much, or to reserve certain styles to people of a specific rank, or perhaps the Emperor, or to adorn the statues of the gods.

Armour and Weapons

So we can now return to Anathaym's shopping trip. With some adjustments in line with pegging prices to the cost of grain, metals and labour, but nevertheless with a large dose of generalisation and guesswork (because we don't have a comprehensive real world ancient price list to refer to), We can price Anathaym's hoplite panoply at something like:

- Spear and Shield: 22SP
- Fancy Helmet: 12SP + 3SP for a simple crest
- Bronze Cuirass: 35SP
- Greaves: 7SP
- Sword: 50SP (Anathaym is after all, wealthy and a bit flashy and inclined to be overcharged by sword cutlers)

A total outlay of 129SP. She is free to spend more by having more embellishments added, perhaps bringing the total cost up to 150-200SP.

It looks like we have a very significant mismatch between the pricing given in game rules compared to realistic pricing based on historical analogues. To some extent this is because this is the stuff adventurers are looking to upgrade all the time and pricing them high provides incentives for progression as characters spend their adventuring loot on training up skills and getting better equipped to take on more dangerous challenges. However a hoplite panoply of spear and shield is reckoned to have cost only around a month's average wages - and adding the simplest form of helmet and leather or cloth armour not much more than

Armour and Weapons	
Simple Metal Helmet	5SP
Fancy Metal Helmet	12SP
Spear	2SP
Hoplite Shield	20SP
Sword	25SP - 50SP
Leather Armour (panoply)	10SP (hide) +2SP per location
Linen Armour (linothorax covering chest and abdomen)	25SP
Iron Armour (Mail shirt)	20SP per location
Simple bronze pectoral, front and back	5SP
Bronze Armour (Bell- or Muscle- cuirass)	35SP
Bronze or Iron Greaves, pair	7SP
Added decoration, depending on technique or materials.	2-10SP per location



that. Accessible pricing for armour and weapons is in fact an essential fact of life if your citizens are supposed to present themselves for military service with equipment they have bought themselves (even if helped out by bank of mum and dad). If you take into account the actual cost of key metals such as iron and bronze then even at some of the higher estimates for the weight of ancient armour the majority of the cost is still in the price of skilled workers to produce an item. Even if the choices I have made here are on the lower end, and a bronze cuirass should cost double what I have proposed, the result is still in a different league to the conventional pricing used in the game rules. Bear in mind a rich individual may also deliberately overspend to have their armour pimped up with mouldings and embellishments that don't add anything to the protection afforded, such as silver nipples on a muscled cuirass, or impressive crests on their helmets, and all these things will add to the cost.

Livestock

Slaves and livestock are shown in the same table here. This is an intentionally grim reflection of the fact that human beings are bought and sold for the output they can generate with the strength of their bodies, and are chattel goods same as draft oxen or a riding animal. Children and old people come at a discount –

either because they need to be maintained until useful or because they have few useful years left.

If animals are to be used for food, their price will increase as they get closer to slaughtering age and weight. Up until that point they still need to be pastured and fed – land and fodder cost money, and there's the ongoing risk of loss to disease, predators and thieves. Younger live animals (slaves included) are cheaper as the buyer has to spend money on feeding them until they can be made full use of. For real world creatures the most efficient calorie-provider is the humble pig. A young 60kg pig should on average be worth 20SP in meat, fat and offal and one that has been allowed to reach a mature weight of over 130kg more than twice that.

Slaves and Livestock	
<i>Agricultural Slave</i>	300SP - 450SP
<i>Domestic Slave</i>	400-500SP
<i>Premium Slave</i>	500SP–1,000SP
<i>Oxen, Pair</i>	150SP
<i>Sheep or Goat</i>	6SP
<i>Bull</i>	75SP
<i>Cow</i>	30SP
<i>Horse</i>	500SP
<i>Donkey, Riding</i>	225SP
<i>Donkey, Pack animal</i>	100SP
<i>Camel</i>	375SP
<i>Donkey</i>	120SP
<i>Riding Horse</i>	200SP - 400SP

TRANSPORT and SHIPPING

Transporting goods by land is vastly more expensive than doing so by sea. Cities of any size are almost always on or close to the sea in order to make shipping commodities and other goods in and out a viable process. Ancient land transport is more expensive than during medieval times, apparently because people were limited to oxen for drawing wagons, having not yet invented a horse collar allowing a seriously heavy load to be pulled. The following costs give an idea of how much an

Adventurer will have to pay to ship a big load from one place to another - or alternatively, the sort of money he can charge for doing so himself. These costs include all hands required to do the job, as well as the use of the ship, wagon or beast of burden.

By Road

To shift 1 wagon load, or 500 ENC of goods (using 1 ENC = circa 1kg this is equivalent to about 75 pecks of grain) by ox cart will cost about 40SP per 100 miles; by camel, a load half that size will cost 16SP per 100 miles. A donkey will carry a load of up to 100 ENC for 8SP per 100 miles.

By Sea

Shipping by sea is much cheaper, at an average of 3SP per 1,000 ENC every 100 miles. Hence a full load of grain on a 250-ton transport ship costs 750SP per 100 miles – which is roughly per day of sailing. The cargo itself is worth 37,500SP.

By River

River traffic is slightly more expensive than seaborne traffic. Assume a cost of 10SP per 1,000 ENC per 100 miles.

Transport	Load per Vessel, Wagon or Animal	Cost per Ton Per 100 Km Transported
<i>Sea</i>	25-500 Tons	3SP
<i>River</i>	1-100 Tons	15SP
<i>Ox Cart</i>	0.5 Tons	80SP
<i>Camel</i>	0.25 Tons	64SP
<i>Donkey or Mule</i>	0.1 Tons	80SP

